

you cannot easily uninstall the system if you want to move house; so you may have to leave an expensive installation behind and pay out again for a new installation in your new home.

A wireless system is easier to install. In fact, most people can set it up on their own. Wireless doesn't require draping cords throughout your home. The downside is that wireless signals can be blocked or interfered with.

Wireless alarm systems are ideal for the DIY'er as they are relatively simple to install. These are great if you are on a budget as you can install just one or two sensors in the first instance and add more later on. If you decide to expand and extend your property, this flexibility allows you to add more sensors easily. You can easily move wireless sensors if desired. The downside with wireless sensors is that you will need to change the batteries regularly.

Buying tips

For a layman it is difficult to understand the technicalities in an electronic device; in this case a home security system. But before investing in any device for your home let us learn some basics. The most important thing is to know what you are looking for. Start with a safety audit to know your house first.

You must carefully survey your home and figure out all the vulnerable entry points including doors, windows, ventilators, etc. Put yourself in the mind of the burglar; how would you break into your home if your got locked out or lost your keys? If you know of at least one easy way into your property then your home is at serious risk.

If you have old rotting window frame or doors then a thief will be through these in seconds. As part of your home security strategy you must remove your property's weaknesses as well as purchase a home security system. Decide how many sensors you need. Decide on the zones you need to secure. Do you want an external bell/siren box? The answer to these questions will have a bearing on what type of security system you choose.

After knowing the entry points you need to figure out where you should place your security devices. For example, video surveillance cameras can either be put in plain view or hidden. In plain view, potential burglars might just be frightened off. Even fake cameras in plain sight might ward-off thieves! However, there is a risk of the camera being disabled by determined intruders.

The most important parameter for purchase of a product like this is 'requirement or usage.'

The market today is full with various options and hence until and unless there is clarity in type of usage of the camera, purchase decision may become difficult. Buyer must first classify whether it's an outdoor or indoor requirement. The second point of differentiation is the optical zoom required.

If you do not have enough knowledge then your system installer can provide a demo so that you understand the system functionality before buying and then choose the right product for you.

Your home security system is designed to protect you against threats to your home. While any system is better than none, the fact of the matter is that there can be many different layers or levels to your home security system. Understanding those levels can help you design a system that's robust, affordable, and gives you the peace of mind you want and need.

Here are the levels that we use to break down home security alarm systems:

Perimeter security. This is security that looks at the openings to the property, or specifically to your domicile. Perimeter security usually relies on physical barriers such as fences and locks. Alarm components at the perimeter level include things like motion-detecting light or perhaps magnetic sensors that tell you when doors or windows are opened.

Back-up perimeter security. These are secondary security measures that apply to the perimeter. Usually, when we talk about perimeter backup, we're

talking about home entrances that have glass. Glass break sensors or shock sensors are examples.

Interior security. Interior security includes home security system components that are actually installed inside the house. This might include something as simple as a home security camera, or it can include high-tech floor sensors, motion detectors, etc.

Personal security. The personal security component actually protects you on an individual level. Generally speaking, these components refer to threats that aren't related to a home invasion, such as smoke, carbon monoxide, or other types of deadly situations. Smoke detectors fall into this category if they are wired into the home security system.

Asset security. Asset security protects your home against environmental hazards. For example, it can include temperature sensors. These components protect your home when the normal environmental controls aren't enough to handle what's going on.

Aesthetics also play an important role in choosing home security devices since these are available in various designs to suit your choice.

One major aspect that needs to be considered before buying the right type of home security system is the price attached to it. Today we are technologically enhanced and have many low- and high-cost security options available in the market. These days you can secure your entire home with as low as ₹ 15,000. But the actual cost depends on the devices you select while customising your home security system; for example, number of cameras, types of sensors, etc. It depends on the type of product, brand, professionalism and experience of system installer. Depending on your budget you can select the best suited for you.

When buying a security product, one should think that he is not simply buying a product but the security for his dream home so he should not compromise on the same. And most importantly, make use of the systems installed! ●

The author is assistant editor for Electronics For You magazine